Committee: United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)

Topic: The Question of Strengthening International Action against Synthetic Drug Trafficking

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Introduction

Until a few years ago, the world had been focusing on regulating plant grown drugs such as cocaine and heroin. However, as technologies developed, now synthetic drugs which happen to be much more sophisticated are rising as the problem. Fentanyl, methamphetamine, and new psychoactive substances (NPS), lab-made chemicals engineered to mimic or alter the effects of traditional illicit drugs, have quickly become a worldwide crisis considering health concerns. According to the UN World Drug Report 2026, global drug use has expanded to an estimated 331 million people which is a 20% increase over the past decade, while synthetic substances continue to reshape illicit markets.

Synthetic drug trafficking means to illegally manufacture, transport and distribute chemical substances. While natural drugs grow from nature, synthetic drugs are chemically made. Traffickers take legal industrial chemicals and use them in hidden labs to make the drugs. This chemical manufacturing method allows traffickers to produce powerful drugs anywhere without any space constraints at a low cost. Since synthetic drugs have big impacts even in small amounts, they are packed in a very small size. Moreover, most of the drugs come in many forms, including powders and pills and they are sold online. Therefore they are easily trafficked everywhere and are good at avoiding any regulations. These criminals can change the chemical composition of a drug by only a tiny amount, sometimes changing just a single molecule. Since this new version has not yet officially been added to the ban list, it can be used legally for the time being. It takes governments months or years to enact a new law for every new substance, but criminals can create a new drug in just a few days. This creates a dangerous legal loophole. Since these drugs are made at random in secret laboratories, people often have no idea at all about how powerful or toxic they are. Because of this unpredictability, emergency room visits, and overdose cases are increasing especially among younger

people. Therefore, finding a way to fill this legal gap more quickly has become an urgent task for countries around the world.

Definition of Key Terms

Synthetic Drugs

Synthetic drugs are products containing chemical substances artificially developed to copy the effects of illegal drugs. They are usually mixed with other drugs or chemically created in a lab to mimic other drugs. They have effects on the brain and behavior. However, since the drugs are created illegally, their ingredients and powder are hard to find. People who consume synthetic drugs could have effects of anxiety, aggressive behavior, loss of consciousness, and even coma or death. What makes these physical dangers more severe is that these chemical materials are getting produced at a very rapid speed. Now, most of the drugs are manufactured in countries that are known for their sophisticated chemical manufacturing industries. For example, as India and China have improved chemical expertise to supply the raw materials, the actual production of synthetic drugs takes place in countries like Myanmar, Mexico and Syria. Then, the drugs would be sent to other parts of the world like Asia, Europe, Australia, etc. Just a few pounds of these substances can give hundreds of thousands of dollars in profit and have a massive impact on the global health and community safety.

Precursor Chemicals

Precursor chemicals are chemicals known to be used in the illegal manufacture of narcotic drugs and psychoactive substances. Since many of these compounds are important for legitimate industries like medicine, plastic, and agriculture, governments strictly monitor them instead of banning them. Acetone, Hydrochloric Acid, and pseudoephedrine are some examples of precursor chemicals. The INCB's (International Narcotics Control Board) mission is to prevent the diversion of these precursor chemicals and controlled substances from getting into the illegal market and safeguard their use for legitimate scientific and medical purposes.

New Psychoactive Substance (NPS)

New psychoactive substance (NPS) is defined as a new narcotic or psychotropic drug, in pure form or in preparation, that is not controlled by the United Nations drug conventions, but which may pose a public threat comparable to that posed by substances listed in these conventions. NPS are often called legal highs or designer drugs and are often not controlled by law. According to the UNODC, NPS have become a global phenomenon with 153 countries and territories from all regions of the

world having reported one or more NPS to the UNODC Early Warning Advisory (EWA) on NPS. Furthermore, while most NPS are synthetic, not all synthetic drugs are NPS. Since their emergence, NPS have been known in the market by terms such as “designer drugs”, “legal highs”, “herbal highs”, and “bath salts”.

Dark Web

The dark web is the part of the internet where users can access unindexed web content anonymously through special web browsers. Though the dark web is popularly associated with illegal activities, it is also used by the intelligence community, whistleblowers, members of the media, and ordinary citizens whose communication may be monitored or restricted by the government. Because of this anonymity, the dark web is also used for the trade and distribution of illegal synthetic drugs. Moreover, since the sellers and buyers can transact using cryptocurrencies and other means without meeting face to face, it makes the detection of synthetic drugs even more difficult.

Synthetic Opioids

Synthetic opioids are chemically synthesized drugs designed to produce effects similar to those of natural opioids such as morphine or heroin, and some substances have much higher potency and unpredictable risks than conventional opioids. Synthetic opioids are a type of synthetic drug and can be classified into drugs legally manufactured for medical purposes and substances illegally manufactured and distributed. Fentanyl, a representative synthetic opioid, is used in medical settings for its powerful pain-relieving effects, but illegally manufactured fentanyl is widely distributed in the international illegal drug market due to its low production cost and high potency, becoming a serious problem. In addition, with the recent emergence of new synthetic opioids such as nitazene, existing regulatory and detection systems are struggling to quickly identify and control newly emerging substances. In particular, illegally manufactured synthetic opioids can be traded anonymously on the dark web and through cryptocurrencies, and when distributed mixed with other drugs, users may find it difficult to recognize the active ingredient, thereby increasing the risk of overdose and death.

Clandestine Drug Labs

A clandestine drug lab is a location used to illegally produce illicit substances. It may involve mixing chemicals to create drugs or pressing powders into pills. Most often, clandestine drug labs are used to make synthetic drugs. Clandestine labs can be found almost anywhere, but are often found in

residential properties, warehouses and commercial properties. The smaller labs such as those in the trunk of a vehicle can be the most dangerous because of their simplicity and portability. Ingredients can be mixed in drinking bottles that can become explosive. Furthermore, the chemicals coming out from the laboratories can contaminate buildings, furniture, soil, water, and air within or close to the clandestine lab.

Early Warning Advisory (EWA)

The UNODC Early Warning Advisory (EWA) serves as a global drug early warning system. It was established in response to the emergence of New Psychoactive Substances (NPS) at the global level as a monitoring tool and knowledge hub for policymakers, laboratories and law enforcement. The Early Warning Advisory aims to monitor, analyse, and report on NPS trends as a basis for effective evidence based policy responses. Moreover, it helps to identify the most harmful, persistent and prevalent NPS so that they can be prioritized for international control.

Background Information

The History of Synthetic Drugs

Synthetic drugs such as the synthetic marijuana “Spice” and “K2,” as well as the synthetic cathinones Bath salts, began to appear on the market when Spice was first commercially sold in London, UK, in 2004. These chemicals, originally developed by scientists such as Professor John Huffman for purely scientific research purposes, were soon commercialized by traders and packaged under deceptive names such as “herbal incense” or “bath salts”. Manufacturers attached misleading labels on product surfaces to avoid drug-related laws, but in reality, they disguised and sold them through retail stores and the internet as legal, harmless, and non-addictive substitutes for marijuana. Around 2008, various competing brands spread rapidly across the United States, and in November of the same year, they were officially identified for the first time by the U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP).

Due to public misunderstanding and deceptive marketing that products are safe because they are legal, abuse of synthetic drugs has surged explosively despite government health warnings and preventive education. Just three years after entering the U.S., in 2011, Spice and K2 had become the second most abused substance among teenagers, with 11.4% of U.S. 12th grade students using them. Users approached it either because they fell for marketing claims of providing hallucinogenic pleasure or to avoid drug testing. However, the actual danger was far more lethal than natural marijuana or regular amphetamines. Severe anxiety, panic attacks, hallucinations, seizures, as well as psychotic symptoms that lasted for days and intense addictive effects, led to tragic outcomes such as suicide or severe behavioral disorders.

As the synthetic drug crisis worsened, the U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA) took legal regulatory action by designating five major chemicals used in synthetic marijuana as illegal controlled substances. However, manufacturers have continuously circumvented the law by using loopholes that subtly alter the chemical structure each time a new regulation is introduced. Since synthetic substances are being produced and distributed faster than legal crackdowns, synthetic drugs remain a persistent social threat to this day, causing serious physical and psychological harm to countless users and demanding long-term treatment.

The Growing Scale of Synthetic Drug Abuse

The synthetic drugs and illegal drugs market has shown explosive statistical growth worldwide over the past decade. According to a report by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), there has been a significant global increase in the trafficking and pricing of synthetic drugs, particularly fentanyl and synthetic opioids. To be specific, an estimated 331 million people used an illicit drug in 2026. The rapid proliferation of these substances has enabled drug trafficking organizations to expand their operations into new regions and markets. This trend raises serious concerns, particularly regarding the lack of centralized hubs for these substances and the challenges inherent in international efforts to combat drug trafficking and protect public health.

The scale of this growth can be clearly seen in recent data from the UNODC. In 2024, authorities identified a total of 755 new psychoactive substances, including 118 newly reported substances and the number of seized drug types became 5 times higher than before 2000. At the same time, the global opioid market is being reshaped around synthetic substances. Since Afghanistan's opium production ban in 2022, heroin production has declined, while drug traffickers are turning to synthetic opioids such as fentanyl and nitazene. Unlike Afghanistan’s opium production, which exceeded 6000 tons in 2022, Myanmar's production in 2025 was above 1000 tons, meaning that synthetic opioids may be gradually filling the gap left by traditional opioids. Because synthetic opioids require no agricultural land and offer far lower production costs, they offer a highly lucrative alternative for traffickers. These figures show how rapidly synthetic drugs are diversifying and spreading into the global illicit drug market.

This mass spread is directly leading to a deadly public health crisis at the national level . In particular, in North America, the abuse of synthetic opioids, including fentanyl, and synthetic stimulants causes tens of thousands of overdose deaths each year, setting new record breaking figures. The skyrocketing global circulation by tons and the accumulating number of deadly deaths each year clearly prove that the synthetic drug problem is moving beyond individual misconduct toward a global scale crisis.

Harms of Synthetic Drugs

Synthetic drugs are so addictive that it is hard to stop. Any drugs are accompanied by dangers and those could include overdose, addiction, damage to relationships, etc. To be specific, in April 2011, in Washington, the father is believed to have killed their son and drove away. While speeding, they were chased by police, and in the process, the father shot his wife with a gun and then took his own life later too. Later, bath salts, a synthetic drug with effects similar to methamphetamine, were

found in the father's pockets and inside the vehicle. At home the child was found killed. Like this, synthetic drugs can cause unpredictable damage. Moreover, synthetic drugs are now usually abused among teens and young adults, and the age of first drug use is getting lower.

Synthetic drugs not only destroy individuals and families, but their enormous demand also provides a lifeline of powerful criminal organizations and global trafficking networks. Mexico's illegal synthetic drug market is controlled by two rival organizations the Sinaloa Cartel and the Jalisco New Generation Cartel. They operate most of the fentanyl and methamphetamine manufacturing facilities in Mexico, control major ports for importing chemical precursors, and control key border areas used to smuggle drugs into the United States. While Sinaloa relies on its established business network and financial system, CJNG seizes control of the distribution channels by mobilizing its strong military power and violence. Because the two cartels are leading the global supply of fentanyl, they are the top targets of international law enforcement and sanctions.

The global trafficking of synthetic drugs, especially illegal fentanyl and methamphetamine, depends on a complex multinational supply chain. The precursor chemicals used as raw materials for drug manufacturing are mainly sourced from chemical manufacturers in Asia and transported by international sea freight to Latin America, with Mexico serving as the main manufacturing hub. Finished synthetic opioid products and stimulants produced in these secret manufacturing facilities are smuggled north across the U.S-Mexico border through commercial freight, passenger vehicles, postal services, and underground border tunnels. Although North America remains a major destination due to huge demand, synthetic drug trafficking networks are gradually expanding into regions such as Western Europe, Oceania, and Southeast Asia.

Chemical Variations of New Synthetic Drugs and the Limits of Detection

Detecting synthetic drugs is difficult since their chemical structures are constantly changing. Manufacturers of synthetic drugs modify their molecular makeup to create new compounds that evade detection by standard drug tests. Most standard drug tests only screen for a limited number of substances. Synthetic drugs are often not included in these panels because they have not yet been identified or classified. Therefore, this makes it difficult for standard tests to keep up with the constantly changing structures. This can lead to unreliable test results and misinterpretations.

Despite the strict regulatory crackdowns by governments around the world, new types of drugs continue to spread and frequently appear in the media because of the diversification of global

supply chains and the sharp rise in drug trafficking through digital platforms. In addition, as an environment has been created through the Dark Web and encrypted messaging apps that allow even ordinary people and adolescents to obtain items easily without face-to-face contact, a social risk structure has appeared in which the existing investigative and legal control systems alone are insufficient to regulate the pace of supply and consumption.

Possible solutions

Strengthening Control over Chemical Transactions

To stop the production of illicit synthetic drugs, the community should prioritize strict regulation of the trade of precursor chemicals. Governments may establish government-led AI monitoring systems for chemical transactions. To overcome the limits of people monitoring all the time, governments may not only make chemical companies monitor but also establish AI-based monitoring systems to see all precursor trades. The AI system would check out all the trades for 24 hours. Moreover, if there happen to be any suspicious trades, AI detection would be able to detect all of them, for example orders that are too large for a company, unusual payment methods or shell companies. Furthermore, when it detects suspicious transactions, the system can hold the trade before the chemicals are shipped. The transactions can remain held until the government inspectors review and approve them. By replacing any slow work with AI, countries may monitor international trades without any gap and stop illicit diversions.

Enforcing Strict Oversight on Drug Manufacturing Equipment

In order to significantly block the mass production of synthetic drugs, the entire process of production, distribution, and import, export of special manufacturing equipment such as the pill press machine, large industrial mixers, and chemical reactors should be strictly managed by the nation. Moreover, nations can require equipment manufacturers and distributors to verify the buyers' identities and register unique serial numbers for each piece of equipment, and establish an integrated registration system to track the movement of special equipment during border clearance. In addition, to prevent equipment from entering through illegal hidden factories, the registration process will also be required for secondhand equipment transactions. Legal and administrative mechanisms can be activated to proactively detect unauthorized equipment trades or attempts at disguised purchase through a tracking database shared by law enforcement and customs.

Targeting High Risk Split Shipments through Integrated Electronic Tracking Systems

Increasing transparency throughout the whole international postal and express freight supply chain is important in order to stop the smuggling of synthetic drugs in small, split shipments. To identify high-risk cargo before it reaches customs, carriers must submit Advance Electronic Data

(AED) for all border shipping cargo , which would include information on the shipper, destination, and the items. At transportation centers and customs checkpoints, AI based X-ray scanning and data analysis systems would be installed. These systems automatically sort and seize cargo that shows unusual shipping patterns or whose declared details do not match the real cargo form.

Running Prevention Education and Raising Public Awareness to Drop Demand

Along with supply control, to effectively reduce drug demand, the government must implement strong educational programs and public safety campaigns throughout the communities. Schools may introduce an essential curriculum to inform young students about the serious dangers of illegal drugs, with particular emphasis on the risks of counterfeit prescription drugs, many of which contain lethal ingredients. At the same time, health authorities can establish a community alert system and distribute life saving medications in case of overdose to emergency responders and their families. Moreover, nations can run social media campaigns to correct misconceptions about drug safety. By providing information to youth early and delivering prompt assistance to those at risk, communities can significantly reduce overall drug use.

Expansion of Legislation to Regulate New Hazardous Chemicals

To prevent illicit drug manufacturers from evading the law by making slight modifications to parts of chemical formulas, the government could improve the management of hazardous substances. Instead of spending months banning each new substance individually, nations can introduce legislation that automatically bans entire groups of similar chemicals based on their chemical structure and harmfulness. The government can take measures to ensure that chemical experts and law enforcement authorities jointly manage the list of prohibited chemical groups so that any new modified substances are declared illegal as soon as they are created. Furthermore, countries should establish a rapid international alert system that shares information on newly laboratory produced chemical substances enabling customs authorities to identify and block new material before it spreads worldwide.

Increasing Punishment and Seizing Money from Drug Networks

To cut off the financial incentives that enable large scale drug smuggling, countries must impose harsher prison sentences and thoroughly confiscate all assets of criminal organizations. Law enforcement agencies and courts must be legally obligated to immediately freeze and recover illegal

proceeds related to drug crimes including cash, bank accounts, real estate, and digital currency. Rather than focusing solely on arresting low level dealers, law enforcement can use financial tracking tools to trace and apprehend senior executives of an organization. The funds and assets recovered from drug cartels can be directly reinvested in expanding local police equipment, strengthening border control systems, and operating drug rehabilitation treatment centers.

Strengthening Multilateral Cooperation and Global Frameworks

To effectively counter transnational synthetic drug networks, member states must enhance international cooperation that transcends national borders. By operationalizing tools such as the INCB's Global Rapid Interdiction of Dangerous Substances (GRIDS) Program, it has become possible to share real time information regarding non-scheduled chemicals. Furthermore, participation in multilateral initiatives - such as the Global Coalition to Address Synthetic Drug Threats - facilitates collaborative law enforcement, tailored technical assistance, and capacity building, enabling developing nations to strengthen their border control and forensic capabilities.

Prioritizing Public Health, Treatment, and Harm Reduction

A balanced international drug policy must place equal emphasis on health centered responses. Member states should expand evidence-based harm reduction strategies, such as community access to overdose reversal medications like naloxone, drug checking services, and voluntary rehabilitation programs. Integrating health and harm reduction into national systems can help reduce stigma and address the root causes of drug demand. Furthermore, by prioritizing medical support over strict criminalization, individuals are enabled to access long term recovery services. This integrated approach ultimately lowers overall public healthcare costs and fosters sustainable community safety.

Balancing Technological Surveillance with Human Rights and Justice

While AI driven surveillance and strengthened legal penalties target illicit networks such measures must respect international human rights standards. Automated monitoring of chemical trade and digital communications can raise concerns regarding data privacy, due process, and the risk of false positives. Consequently, governance frameworks must incorporate judicial oversight and strict data protection. Furthermore, law enforcement agencies should target high level transnational

syndicates rather than low level, vulnerable individuals, acknowledging the limits of purely punitive strategies.

Major parties involved

People's Republic of China

China is a major global supplier and distributor of synthetic, laboratory-produced drugs and precursor chemicals. Transnational criminal organizations and chemical industries are utilizing these resources to manufacture synthetic opioids, illicit stimulants, and alternative compounds. Facing significant international pressure, China has taken important steps to mitigate the crisis. In 2019, it placed all fentanyl related substances under comprehensive regulatory control. Furthermore, it has established joint anti narcotics task forces with foreign partners, most notably U.S. law enforcement agencies. However, significant challenges remain. Suppliers continue to exploit legal loopholes by shifting to unregulated precursor chemicals. In discussions, China is expected to emphasize the principle of "shared responsibility," arguing that consumer nations must address the demand for drugs within their own borders. This stance rejects unilateral blame or sanctions directed solely at chemical producing nations. Moreover, China advocated for international cooperation that respects national sovereignty.

United Mexican States

Mexico serves as a major transit and manufacturing hub for the global illicit drug trade. Usually, the Sinaloa Cartel and the Jalisco New Generation Cartel (CJNG) are the two major organizations that are leading the trade. These transnational criminal organizations import large quantities of precursor chemicals from Asia and process them in secret laboratories into finished synthetic opioids, particularly fentanyl. The Sinaloa Cartel and CJNG lead the worldwide distribution of these illegal drugs by utilizing advanced trafficking infrastructure and managing key border crossings. In response, Mexico is intensifying its law enforcement operations. It is strictly enforcing regulations on the import of precursor chemicals, dismantling clandestine laboratories, and extraditing high ranking cartel figures for prosecution. Within the UNODC framework, Mexico is likely to advocate for tighter controls on the export of precursor chemicals from their countries of origin.

The Republic of the Union of Myanmar

Transnational criminal organizations in Myanmar have greatly increased the number of clandestine methamphetamine manufacturing facilities across uncontrolled border regions, thanks to

recent political instability and intensifying conflict between citizens. These organizations source precursor chemicals from neighboring countries, process them, and distribute high-quality methamphetamine and heroin to markets across the Asia-Pacific region and beyond. Persistent internal strife and institutional instability severely hinder national law enforcement efforts. Despite international crackdowns, disrupting these illicit supply chains remains a formidable challenge. Officially, Myanmar emphasizes the gravity of its domestic security concerns, advocating for non punitive technical assistance and support for regional border management. Furthermore, the country calls for international development aid to address the underlying socioeconomic root causes for drug production.

Republic of India

India recognizes the spread of synthetic drugs as a serious security and public health issue that the international community must address jointly. India's advanced chemical and pharmaceutical sectors, combined with its geographical location, create a position of vulnerability. Criminals exploit these factors to produce and distribute precursor chemicals. In response, the Indian government is tightening regulations on dual use of precursor chemicals, expanding surveillance along smuggling routes, and intensifying crackdowns on illicit manufacturing facilities. India maintains that the issue of synthetic drugs cannot be addressed by any single nation alone. Therefore, it advocates for real time information sharing, joint international investigations, and collaborative responses to transnational networks. At the same time, India emphasizes that global regulations must not hinder legitimate medical and pharmaceutical activities.

United States of America

The United States is the world's primary consumer market for illicit synthetic drugs, particularly fentanyl. This issue has created a severe public health crisis, resulting in tens of thousands of overdose deaths annually. In response, the U.S. has implemented strict regulations on fentanyl and related substances, while intensifying oversight of precursor chemicals and manufacturing equipment. Furthermore, the U.S. has expanded international investigations targeting transnational criminal organizations. While addressing domestic demand and treatment challenges, the U.S. is also spearheading multilateral initiatives - such as the Global Coalition to Address Synthetic Drug Threats - aimed at disrupting illicit supply chains from their points of origin all the way to national borders. In international forums, the U.S. is advocating for binding global regulations on currently uncontrolled precursor chemicals. It calls for the immediate, real time sharing of data, the implementation of class

wide bans on new synthetic analogs, and the enforcement of strict accountability for countries that serve as a source of transit points for these substances.

International Narcotics Control Board

The International Narcotics Control Board (INCB) monitors global compliance with UN drug control conventions. It emphasizes the importance of real time international information sharing and the strict regulation of new synthetic substances and precursor chemicals. The INCB actively encourages governments to share information regarding emerging drug threats, a process supported by its GRIDS program. Furthermore, the board tracks the cross border movement of dual use chemicals. Recognizing that law enforcement measures alone are insufficient to curb illicit trade conducted via the internet or international shipping, the INCB strongly advocates for public private partnerships. Strengthening early detection and prevention requires collaboration with companies in the chemical, logistics, and online platform sectors.

Timeline Of Events

Date	Description of Event
First Synthesis of Chloral Hydrate, 1832	The German chemist Justus von Liebig synthesized chloral hydrate. This was later recognized as the first synthetic pharmaceutical compound.
First Synthesis of Amphetamine, 1887	A Romanian chemist synthesized amphetamine for the first time at the university of Berlin.
Synthesis of MDMA, 1912	MDMA was first synthesized in 1912 by the German Chemist while working for the pharmaceutical company Merck.
Development of Pharmaceutical Fentanyl, 1959	In 1959, Belgian chemists synthesized fentanyl, a revolutionary synthetic opioid designed to provide powerful pain relief with superior stability.
Convention on Psychotropic Substances of 1971, February 21, 1971	The UN established an international treaty to control depressants, stimulants and hallucinogens to prevent abuse while safeguarding their availability for medical use.
1988 UN Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances, December 20, 1988	This treaty established international standards for controlling drug related money laundering and precursor chemicals.
Launch of the UNODC Global SMART Programme, September 2008	Established to help governments generate, manage, and share information about the threats of synthetic drugs.
Global Explosion of New Psychoactive Substances(NPS), 2010s	the global drug market experienced a dramatic rise in New Psychoactive Substances (NPS)
Surge of Illicit Fentanyl and Synthetic Opioid Crisis, 2013-2014	Fentanyl and other synthetic opioids have surged into the supply chain.

UN General Assembly Special Session on the World Drug Problem, April 2016	Marked a critical shift toward a more balanced, human rights focused approach to global drug policy.
Establishment of the Global Coalition to Address Synthetic Drug Threats, July 7, 2023	Nations united to disrupt illicit precursor chemical supply chains, detect new synthetic drugs, and enhance global public health responses
Adoption of CND Resolution 69/3, March 2026	Urges Member States to strengthen early warning systems, real-time data collection, and information sharing to rapidly detect and respond to emerging synthetic drug threats

UN Involvement, Resolutions, Treaties and Events

- Strengthening early warning mechanisms consisting of monitoring and assessment systems to enable effective responses to the emergence of new synthetic drugs, new psychoactive substances, and precursors, including pre-precursors and designer precursors, March 2026

  The resolution focuses on strengthening international and national capacities to address evolving threats posed by synthetic drugs, new psychoactive substances and precursor chemical substances not included in the list of substances subject to regulation. This resolution emphasizes that thorough data collection, enhanced forensic surveillance, and risk assessment are essential to identify new synthetic compounds before they spread across borders. Furthermore, this resolution calls on member states to promote real time information sharing between health authorities and law enforcement agencies by utilizing multilateral platforms such as the UNODC's Global Smart Program and the International Narcotics Control Board (INCB) system. The international community aims to accelerate law enforcement and public health level responses to the illegal trafficking and manufacture of synthetic drugs by improving early warning infrastructure and cross border operational cooperation.

- Strengthening international cooperation and comprehensive regulatory and institutional frameworks for the control of precursors used in the illicit manufacture of narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances, 2019

  This resolution emphasizes the urgent need to address not only the illegal use of essential precursors such as acetic anhydride, which criminal organizations exploit, but also the illegal use of pre-precursors and alternative chemicals that are not included in the list of regulated substances. It also urges member states to revise their domestic legislation and strengthen controls on border and internal circulation. In addition, this resolution focuses on the importance of public-private cooperation and encourages the government, through a voluntary code of conduct, to work with the chemical industry and collaborate with digital platforms to prevent the illegal online distribution of precursor substances.

- Resolution adopted by the General Assembly on 18 December 2023

This resolution was adopted to address the escalating global threat of synthetic drugs, such as illicit fentanyl. It emphasizes that Member States must balance public health interventions with law enforcement strategies. The resolution calls for stronger international cooperation, improved data sharing via UN agencies, and closer partnerships with the private sector to disrupt the trafficking of non-scheduled precursor chemicals and internet-based drug distribution platforms.

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